

Chapter One

The caravans moved at night, when the sand was cold and the stars were a map. Ibn Battuta counted forty camels at the first well, each carrying salt cut from the pans at Taghaza.

Nobody lived at Taghaza by choice. The miners were sent, and they stayed, and the wind polished the walls of their philosophy until the salt houses shone in the moonlight.

Chapter Two

Twenty days without a well. The guides navigated by the shape of the dunes and by a memory of stars handed down for six generations of traders crossing the empty quarter.